

The Noble Sūtra of the Four Truths

Ārya Catuḥsatya Sūtra · Toh 316 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་བདེན་པ་བཞི་མཛད།

The Noble Sūtra of the Four Truths, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Catuḥsatya Sūtra and in Tibetan as Pakpa Denpa Shyi'i Do (པཀཔ་དེན་པ་ཤི་ཡི་དོ), is a sūtra in which the Buddha expounds the Four Noble Truths to an assembly of monks, emphasizing that ignorance of these truths is the very cause of beings' continued wandering in saṃsāra. The teaching is set at a royal residence between the cities of Campā and Rājagṛha, where the Buddha addresses his monastics directly in the first person, underscoring the shared journey of teacher and disciples through cycles of existence. This text is Toh 316 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the general class of sūtra literature.

In the language of India: Ārya Catuḥsatya Sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Noble Sūtra of the Four Truths.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One was dwelling in the evening at the royal residence called the Bamboo Staff of Āmrapālī, which lies midway between the city of Campā and Rājagṛha, together with a great Saṅgha of monks.

Then the Blessed One addressed the monks: "Monks, it is because we alone — you and I — did not know, did not see, did not penetrate, and did not individually realize the Four Noble Truths that we have been running and wandering in this long journey of saṃsāra. What are those four? It is because we alone — you and I — did not know, did not see, did not penetrate, and did not individually realize the noble truth of suffering that we have been running and wandering in this long journey of saṃsāra. It is because we alone — you and I — did not know, did not see, did not penetrate, and did not individually realize the noble truth of the origin of suffering that we have been running and wandering in this long journey of saṃsāra. It is because we alone — you and I — did not know, did not see, did not penetrate, and did not individually realize the noble truth of the cessation of suffering that we have been running and wandering in this long journey of saṃsāra. It is because we alone — you and I — did not know, did not see, did not penetrate, and did not individually realize the noble truth of the path that leads to the cessation of suffering that we

have been running and wandering in this long journey of saṃsāra.

"Monks, I have followed, realized, and individually understood the noble truth of suffering, and by severing the craving for existence, births in saṃsāra are exhausted, and now there is no further existence. I have followed, realized, and individually understood the noble truth of the origin of suffering, and by severing that craving for existence, births in saṃsāra are exhausted, and now there is no further existence. I have followed, realized, and individually understood the noble truth of the cessation of suffering, and by severing the craving for existence, births in saṃsāra are exhausted, and now there is no further existence. I have followed, realized, and individually understood the noble truth of the path that leads to the cessation of suffering, and by severing the craving for existence, births in saṃsāra are exhausted, and now there is no further existence."

The Blessed One having declared this, the Sugata, the Well-Gone One, having spoken thus, the Teacher then spoke further in these words:

Because we alone — you and I —
did not see the Four Noble Truths
just as they truly are,
we have wandered long in saṃsāra.

But having seen those truths,
and having severed the craving for existence,
since the births of saṃsāra are exhausted,
now there is no further existence.

When the Blessed One had declared this, those monks rejoiced.

Translator's Notes

- The location given in the Tibetan — a royal residence called "the Bamboo Staff of Āmrāpālī" lying midway between Campā and Rājagṛha — is unusual. The standard parallel in Pāli (Saṃyutta Nikāya 56.21) places the setting at Rājagṛha in the Bamboo Grove; the Tibetan toponym here is distinctive and may reflect a variant textual tradition or a unique transmission. The phrase rendered "the craving for existence" translates "srid pa'i sred pa," literally "the craving or thirst for becoming," which corresponds to Sanskrit bhavaṭṛṣṇā, a precise technical term in the doctrine of dependent origination.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.